countries claimed the right to attack third-country oil tankers that got in the way of their troops.
• Meanwhile, the pro-Iranian Islamic Jihad and the Iranian-dominated “Party of God”—the Hizballah, a group of terrorists based in Syria and trained, equipped, and controlled by Iranian Revolutionary Guards—had embarked on what could only be described as a savage campaign of terrorism against American citizens. We believed that the Hizballah was responsible for the bombings of the marine barracks and of our Beirut embassy in 1983, and for the bombing of our embassy annex there a year later.

Iran’s seizure of American hostages in Teheran and America’s frustrated response to it had given the barbarian Hizballah an idea. They had turned the systematic kidnapping and torture of innocent Americans into an instrument of war that was meant to persuade us to abandon our policies in the Middle East. At the beginning of 1985, they held five American hostages, including William Buckley, the CIA’s station chief in Beirut. Several days into the new year they added a sixth, Father Lawrence Martin Jenco, head of Catholic Relief Services in Lebanon. There would be others.

No problem was more frustrating for me when I was president than trying to get the American hostages home. It was a problem I shared with Jimmy Carter, a problem that confronted me when I entered the White House and that was with me when I left it.

During one of my morning National Security Council briefings on the state of the world someone handed me an album of photographs. At first they looked like ordinary aerial photos of a wilderness. Then I recognized Rancho del Cielo and my horse, El Alamein, and Nancy’s horse, No Strings, grazing in a pasture. The photos had been taken by